

New Venture Awards

Meeting Notes with Professor Ahmed

- Point 1: Communicate clearly that we don't have a venture started yet.
- Also communicate that I was super passionate about this problem for the past 3 years, but coming to college, I realized that I had to settle myself career-wise and financially first so that I can even still stay in the US after graduation, and when I've built a strong company and enough financial backing, I can go into my passion for education.
- Because of this, I've written 2 separate proposals. One for the seeding impact class and the second for a for-profit initiative. I'll only be showing him Both
- If he thinks it's still worth a shot despite not having anything founded yet, he should let me know and we can go ahead
- Show intended response for each question and get feedback

Questions

1. What is the resume aspect of the application?
2. Does he think I should work with the same group members from the class or not for he venture?
- 3.

Initial Round Application

Questions:

Other Team Members (if any)

Headshot(s) (file name should include first and last name per team member)*

Name of your project/venture*

1-2 sentence description of your project/venture*

This may be used in blog posts, social media, and other public platforms. Take care to craft text that is clear, concise, and compelling and that will generate interest in your work.

How did you learn about this grant?*

A person, an e-newsletter, a social media site, or some other source? Please be specific.

Project/venture website(s) or other links

This can include a homepage, social media, or other online destinations where people can learn more about your work

Project/venture logo (if you have one)

Upload 1 supported file. Max 10 MB.

Resume (PDF)*

Upload 1 supported file: PDF or document. Max 10 MB.

Application Questions

Please answer each question via written OR video responses. Each written response can be a maximum of 350 words, and videos 4 min. You must answer all questions to complete your application.

1. Describe the problem your venture will address and the systemic conditions/context(s) for its persistence.

In 2013, one in every five of the world's out-of-school children was in Nigeria. That number has nearly doubled to date, with twenty million children aged 5-14 years out of school. This, compounded with the low literacy rates (only 49% of children in school achieve basic literacy proficiency, and 55% achieve basic numeracy proficiency) ("UNICEF Statistics On Education"), chronic poverty (on average 4 out of 10 individuals in Nigeria has real per capita expenditures below 137,430 Naira - \$85, per year) (National Bureau of Statistics), insecurity, and corruption in the country, effectively ensure that these children remain out of school until employment age. An analysis of these causes is found below. To understand further, we interviewed Tyro and Ibrahim, two young boys currently out of school in Lagos. They expressed difficulty in going to school due to financial hardships and the loss of their primary breadwinners- their fathers (M. Tyro, personal communication, Feb 23, 2025; A. Ibrahim, personal communication, Feb 23, 2025).

Challenge Landscape

There are significant disparities in access to quality education in Lagos. This is due to economic barriers and high levels of socioeconomic inequality, cultural practices and beliefs, and the severe underfunding of the educational sector.

Poverty: The quality of education children receive largely depends on their parents' financial capacity. Private schools are expensive, while public schools suffer from underfunding (National Bureau of Statistics, 2019). In 2019, 40.1% of Nigeria's total population was classified as poor. Many families struggle to afford basic necessities such as food, shelter, and clothing, forcing children to engage in child labor or informal trade instead of attending school (National Bureau of Statistics & International Labour Organization, 2024).

Cultural Barriers: In some regions, cultural biases favor child labor and early marriage over formal education, particularly for girls (Teach for Nigeria, 2023). Some religious leaders and communities view Western-style education with suspicion, associating it with the erosion of local cultural and religious values (Slum2School, 2024).

Underfunding of the Educational System: Nigeria allocates less than 10% of its national budget to education—well below the UNESCO-recommended 15-20% (United Nations Children's Fund, 2023). These limited funds are further reduced due to corruption, including bribes, embezzlement, and favoritism in fund allocation (Transparency International, 2023). Many schools lack basic infrastructure such as classrooms, furniture, and sanitation, and there is a critical shortage of teachers (Punch NG, 2023). Additionally, school locations present a geographical barrier, as long commutes deter students from attending school, particularly in rural areas (Effiong & Okijie, 2022)

2. Describe your connection to this problem and why you are well positioned to tackle it. Why are you the person to address this problem? What skills or abilities do you possess that place you in a position to make an impact? How do you relate to the community/sector experiencing this problem?

The Person:

My experience growing up in Lagos, Nigeria, has given me a level of understanding of the problem. Every day going to school, I would see scores of children just like me, unable to go to school. I went to an expensive private school on a scholarship - and was able to witness the stark differences in educational quality between the private and public school systems in Nigeria. Students at my school had imported textbooks, private tutors, and access to quality facilities. In contrast, some students in public schools often had to share textbooks - sometimes 5 students to one textbook - to deal with overcrowded classrooms and dilapidated facilities (sometimes 70+ students fitting in one classroom), and underpaid teachers who sometimes treated them negatively due to untimely payment. Immersion in this context has given me deep insight to the gaps that need to be filled, as well as solutions that may be effective in solving the problem.

Additionally, my work with the Ekiunu Kiagbodo Kedo Foundation for orphans and widows, an organization that provides books and basic necessities to orphans and widows, has allowed me to directly engage with the communities most affected by educational inequity. After I graduated from high school, my mom went on to work with New Globe education, an NGO that collaborates with governments to enhance educational outcomes by providing digital learning platforms, teacher training, and real-time data analytics. She became Director of Schools at Ecoexcel, and since then we have done numerous rounds of ground-research on out-of-school children, interviewing dozens of children, and partnering with New Globe's expansive database of survey information to identify the most significant gaps for change. To date we have empowered over 30 students to be enrolled in schools, and helped their guardians start some form of trade to fund their education.

Our strategic connection with the Former Minister of Education for Lagos State, Nigeria, Honorable Minister Adefisayo, as well as other executives within the Lagos State Universal Basic Education Board has also expanded our outreach and proximity to figures of power in the existing system. We believe now is the time to synthesize our months of research with the influence of these players and in order to create lasting change for these children.

Can add: - experience at ALA, leadership youth forum ALAMAU, presenting at YYGS, and becoming an ambassador.

3. Describe your venture, its activities, and what makes its approach more unique than other ventures in the space.

Strong applicants demonstrate knowledge of other ventures/organizations/projects in the space, and articulate why their initiative is approaching the problem from a new perspective. Please be sure to note at least one other entity in your space and how your solution differs.

Education for Equality aims to create impact through 3 key main ways -

After doing research into current players in the field, we found that 2 major obstacles hindering faster scaling/ growth is a

categories

- System mapping sheet
- CSPL Pages 21-23

4. How do you plan to make and measure progress/impact over the next year?

Strong applicants will clearly communicate key activities and results/milestones and showcase a feasible timeline for their achievement.

For the next year, we would really like to hone in on the Book Run and the Online Learning Platform, to lay down roots in preparation for the tab project. This is our Plan for progress:

Timeline ->

Talk about OKRs

Break it down by 3 or 4 months

Plan for knowing whether what you're doing is working and adjusting from there

- CUTS -

Additionally, my experience at the African Leadership Academy, a highly-selective leadership institution that selects high potential high school students from all over Africa and trains them to become the next generation of African leaders. My mission going into ALA was simple: to extend educational access for children across Nigeria. I gained entrepreneurial leadership skills through carrying out independent projects

My mother also worked as a teacher at my high school - and later as middle management of an organization that increases educational access to children in Lagos. I've had the opportunity to understand the issues that hinder non-governmental organizations from effectively tackling the issue, including bureaucratic bottlenecks and extra contractual lapses in payment. I've also had the opportunity to engage directly with the communities for which this a deep problem, and understand the pain points affecting them most. This valuable insight has given me unique positionality to the problem, and I have thus based my proposed solution from the context of being immersed in the problem.

The Nigerian government, and indeed, governments across the African continent, have not proven themselves reliable at closing this gap. For Nigeria to catch up, school needs to be brought to the children. Edtech thus presents itself as a meaningful tool to address this issue. Historically, online educational platforms have not been prevalent across Nigeria - primarily because of lack of knowledge of their existence, but also due to lack of knowledge on how to use them. Education for Equality - my proposed solution, aims to change that. By decentralizing education and making it free for all children, we aim to fill educational and technological gaps in Nigeria.

*also explain the point of access to Honorable minister adefisayo and others.

10-Minute Pitch Script for Presentation

We can term it as:

Team:

Naomi Ivie
Amber Bretz

Sonia Ivie -> point out the fact that she has capitalized and connected us with influential people in the educational sector in Lagos, Nigeria.

My mom recently completed a PhD (a study of selected public primary schools through Ecoexcel interventions), through the effect studying the effects of ____ on _____. You can see that the passion for providing educational access runs through the family.

Show a blip of the website - Finish the website within the next 8 days.

1. Fff
2. Fff
3. Fff
- 4.
5. Right now we've done on-the-ground field work unlike any other firm, studying the landscape for the root causes of lack of access to educational access in Lagos, Nigeria. To date we have interviewed children in over 20 communities, we have interviewed over 20 children, here are some of our biggest insights:
6. 20% of children in families stated that their ability to go to school was hindered by insufficient income of their parents. Another 30% stated that their lack of educational access was due to lack of access to proper educational resources, such as proper classrooms and _____. A final 20% stated that

Terrorist Unrest - Cause children's families to be displaced
7. We have recently undergone a detailed systems mapping of the problems plaguing educational access to children in Lagos, Nigeria, which can be found in the handouts being given right now, and identified gaps and levers of change within the system.
8. We have also built an online educational platform that provides free, educational curricula for students between the ages of 5-15
9. Our Team consists of people from finance and educational and policy fields, with each strength complementing the scale of our impact ***
10. We now have yet to implement the Tab Project, a digitally-based *digital literacy initiative that provides tablets preloaded with educational content tailored to Nigeria's curriculum* that will _____
11. We also aim to implement the Book Run, a wide-scale charity event that will distribute unneeded books from community members to under-resourced schools and children with reading ability.

12. Today, we are asking for \$6000, that will cover the cost of the initial pilot of the tablets, state fees, as well as other hardware costs, as well as project our website being online for the next 6 months as we pilot our program. *highlight other costs that are involved but not included in the \$6000.